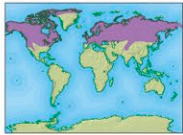


Mustela erminea

Stoat



Length 7½–13½ in (19–34 cm)
Tail 1½–4½ in (4.2–12 cm)
Weight 5–16 oz (140–445 g)
Location North America, Greenland, Europe to N. and E. Asia
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



This extremely widespread mustelid adapts to many habitats, and hunts varied prey from mice, voles, and small birds to rats and, often, rabbits. It has the typical mustelid's long, slim, flexible body, pointed muzzle, small eyes and ears, and short legs. Its weight can vary with location. In the north of its range, the summer coat of russet to ginger-brown above, demarcated from cream or white below, turns all-white for winter, when the stoat is often called the ermine. However, the tail tip is always black.

Mustela nivalis

Least weasel



Length 4½–10 in (11.5–26 cm)
Tail 2¾–2½ in (7–9 cm)
Weight ⅞–9 oz (25–250 g)
Location North America, Europe to N., C., and E. Asia
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



One of the smallest and most widespread mustelids, this weasel has a small, flattened head hardly wider than the neck, allowing it to enter mouse burrows. It also eats voles, other small rodents, and birds. It is active day and night and must consume one-third of its body weight each day to survive. Overall size varies greatly across the huge range and between sexes, with the male being a quarter as long and up to twice the weight of the female. A small



stoat and large least weasel are distinguished by the former's black-tipped tail. Like stoats, least weasels in northern lands turn white in winter, for camouflage in snow. Also like the stoat, this species lives alone, making several nests lined with grass and prey fur or feathers, in a crevice, tree root, or abandoned burrow. After a gestation period of 34–37 days, the female produces a litter of 1–6 (average 3). She cares for them for 9–12 weeks.

Mustela lutreola

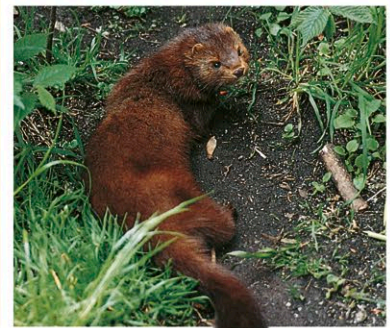
European mink



Length 12–16 in (30–40 cm)
Tail 4¾–7½ in (12–19 cm)
Weight 18–29 oz (500–800 g)
Location Europe
Social unit Individual
Status Endangered



The European mink is similar in habits and appearance to the American mink (below), although slightly smaller. It hunts small prey, such as birds, mammals, frogs, fish, and crayfish, on land and in water. The fur is dark brown to almost black with a narrow white edging to the lips. This endangered mink is being bred in captivity for release.



Mustela putorius

European polecat



Length 8¼–18 in (20.5–46 cm)
Tail 2¾–7½ in (7–19 cm)
Weight ⅞–4 lb (0.4–1.7 kg)
Location Europe
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



long, sinuous body



Regarded as the domestic ferret's ancestor, the polecat has long, buff to black hairs with cream or yellow underfur visible between them, and a "mask" across the face. It runs, climbs, and swims well. If threatened, it releases very pungent-smelling anal-gland secretions. As in many similar mustelids, male neighbors defend separate territories, as do females, but male territories usually overlap female ones.

Mustela nigripes

Black-footed ferret



Length 16–20 in (40–50 cm)
Tail 4½–6 in (11.5–15 cm)
Weight 1¼–2¼ lb (0.8–1.1 kg)
Location Reintroduced to C. USA
Social unit Individual/Pair
Status Endangered



black tail tip



Exceptionally rare, partly due to extermination of its almost exclusive prey of prairie dogs (see p.119), this species was considered extinct in the wild. Captive breeding and release have re-established a few in Wyoming. It chases its prey down burrows and also sets up a nest there, the female giving birth to 3–6 kits.

Neovison vison

American mink



Length 12–17 in (30–43 cm)
Tail 6–8 in (15¼–20 cm)
Weight ⅞–4 lb (0.4–1.8 kg)
Location North America
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



This opportunistic predator uses its partly webbed feet to hunt on land and in water for a variety of small animals, including rats, rabbits, birds, frogs, fish, and crayfish. Since its eyesight is not well adapted for underwater vision, prey is located at the surface and then pursued. In her nesting den among tree roots or rocks, the female suckles 2–10 young for 5–6 weeks. The average litter size is 5. In its natural range, the American mink was once trapped by the thousand; in about 1900 it was taken to

South America, Europe, and Russia for fur farming. Escapees established wild populations and are regarded as threats to local wildlife—not only to prey but also to rival predators.

COLOR VARIATION
Most American minks are dark brown to almost black, but approximately 1 in 10 is gray-blue.



MINK TERRITORIES

American mink are territorial, with typical territory sizes of ½–1¼ miles (1–3 km) across for the female and 1¼–3 miles (2–5 km) for the male. Each marks its territory with urine, droppings, and scents from the anal glands. From February to April, males try to mate with females from adjacent territories.

